Comparatives and superlatives

Goal: To form comparatives and superlatives of short and long adjectives, to use the structures as … as and (not) as … as, and to compare animals, places and environmental problems correctly.

The idea in two lines: A comparative compares two things (bigger than, more dangerous than). A superlative picks one out of a group (the biggest, the most dangerous). The length of the adjective decides the form.

Adjective	Comparative	Superlative
tall (short)	taller than	the tallest
big (1 vowel + 1 cons.)	bigger than	the biggest
dirty (-y)	dirtier than	the dirtiest
polluted (long)	more polluted than	the most polluted

Irregular: good → better → the best; bad → worse → the worst; far → farther → the farthest

Figure 1: Spelling patterns for comparatives and superlatives, with the main irregular adjectives.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Short adjectives** (one syllable): add -er / -est: cold → colder than → the coldest.
2. **Spelling:** one vowel + one consonant → double the consonant (hot → hotter, hottest); final -e → add -r / -st (large → larger, largest); final -y → -ier / -iest (happy → happier, happiest).
3. **Long adjectives** (two syllables or more, except those ending in -y): more / most + adjective: beautiful → more beautiful than → the most beautiful.
4. **Irregular forms** must be learnt: good / better / best, bad / worse / worst, far / farther / farthest, little / less / least, many / much / more / most.
5. **Than** follows a comparative; **the** comes before a superlative, often with "in" (in the world) or "of" (of all).
6. **Equality:** as + adjective + as; **inequality:** not as (so) + adjective + as. "A cheetah is not as heavy as a lion."

7. **Modifiers:** much / far / a lot + comparative (much hotter); by far + superlative.

🟢 Examples

1. Complete: "The Sahara is ___ (large) desert in Africa." **Answer:** the largest. **Explanation:** one thing out of a group, short adjective, final -e so only -st is added.
2. Complete: "City air is ___ (polluted) than mountain air." **Answer:** more polluted. **Explanation:** three syllables, so more + adjective; than is already there.
3. Rewrite keeping the meaning: "The Nile is longer than the Niger." → "The Niger is not ___." **Answer:** The Niger is not as long as the Nile. **Explanation:** not as … as expresses the same comparison from the other side.

🟠 Common BAC mistakes

- Double forms: "more bigger", "the most hottest".
- Writing "that" or "then" instead of **than** after a comparative.
- Forgetting **the** before a superlative or the doubled consonant (biger, hoter).
- Using "gooder" or "badder" instead of better / worse.

🟡 Quick review

- Short adjective: -er than / the -est.
- Long adjective: more … than / the most ….
- -y → -ier / -iest; double the final consonant after one short vowel.
- good → better → best; bad → worse → worst.
- as … as = equal; not as … as = less.

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